leads of the past. Moreover, a globalized world no longer requires all-round development of power to make a nation stand out in competition. If some facets are adequately developed, that in itself provides enough capability to make a difference. It could be military force, as in the past; natural or financial resources; a strategic location; a cutting-edge capability; or an effective platform. A combination of them makes a powerful case for greater influence.

The prominence of such powers is already expressing itself in greater regionalism. Whether in Africa, West Asia, the Gulf or Oceania, differences and disputes are being addressed in a more localized manner. In fact, the openings provided by the transformation underway are so significant that they can be leveraged even by smaller nations.

Few regions have displayed this more graphically than West Asia. Its stronger regionalization has been expressed in conflicts and tensions that are increasingly driven by resident players, both big and small. While the rest of the world continues to have significant stakes, their ability and inclination to intervene is clearly declining. Leveraging of natural resources has long been a tradition. To this has now been added the innovative applications of technology. Whether it is from Yemen or Gaza, we are witnessing how long-standing problems have acquired highly impactful contemporary forms. Much of this has also fed into regional competition, especially of middle powers.

Numerous players operating with greater agility and less constraints in an interdependent world make a compelling case for pragmatism. In certain senses, shared interests can help override ideological or systemic differences. Whether it is in domains of energy, connectivity or technology, those who have little else in common have come together for their individual gains. But here, too, there is a larger structural logic to what is unfolding in front of us. That the unilateralism of any single power is untenable as a standard operating principle is obvious by now. The 1990s are well behind us and cannot be reinvented even by the most powerful of those emerging.

At the same time, the problems of the world have also become so complicated that no bilateral relationship in itself is adequate to be a regular solution provider. Theoretically, there is good old multilateralism to which everyone always pays lip service. But its frailties and shortcomings are even more openly on display. It is not only anachronistic but functions at